

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Jainism - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Jainism

English-first concept spine • Sanskrit/Pali IAST follows in parentheses

- 1 many-sided reality (anekāntavāda)
- 2 qualified assertion (syādvāda)
- 3 sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī)
- 4 liberation (mokṣa)

Read the complete Markdown/PDF for arguments, objections, PYQs and model answers.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Jainism - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	11

Jainism - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed. across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

1. Which statement most accurately identifies the place of the Tattvārthasūtra in Jaina philosophy?

A. It is a systematic Sanskrit exposition attributed to Umāsvāti/Umāsvāmī and accepted as authoritative by both major sects. B. It is chiefly a biography of Mahāvīra with no systematic metaphysics. C. It is a Śvetāmbara canonical Āgama rejected by all Digambaras. D. It establishes a creator God as the source of action and moral consequence (karma).

Answer: A. It is a systematic Sanskrit exposition attributed to Umāsvāti/Umāsvāmī and accepted as authoritative by both major sects.

The text supplies a shared doctrinal grammar for knowledge, reality, action and moral consequence (karma) and liberation despite sectarian differences elsewhere. It presents the ratnatraya and major metaphysical categories. Tīrthaṅkaras are liberated teachers, not creator Gods.

2. Which is a real substance (dravya) but not an astikāya?

A. Conscious soul (jīva) B. Kāla C. Dharma D. Ākāśa

Answer: B. Kāla

Jainism recognises six substance (dravyas) but only five astikāyas. Conscious soul (jīva), pudgala, dharma, adharma and ākāśa possess extension through many pradeśas; kāla accounts for succession and change but is not an astikāya.

3. In the formula utpāda-vyaya-dhauvya-yuktaṃ sat, the real is characterised by:

A. creation, preservation and destruction by God. B. substance, universal and inherence. C. origination, decay and persistence together. D. momentary arising without an enduring aspect.

Answer: C. origination, decay and persistence together.

Jaina realism preserves both identity and change. A mode originates and another ceases while the substance (dravya) persists. The formula therefore resists both pure flux and an absolutely changeless reality.

4. Which option correctly states the relation among substance (dravya), quality (guṇa) and mode (paryāya)?

A. Quality (guṇa) and mode (paryāya) are interchangeable names for momentary events. B. Substance (dravya) is unreal, while qualities (guṇas) alone exist. C. Mode (paryāya) is permanent, while substance (dravya) arises and ceases. D. Substance (dravya) is substance, qualities (guṇas) are abiding qualities, and paryāyas are changing modes.

Answer: D. Substance (dravya) is substance, qualities (guṇas) are abiding qualities, and paryāyas are changing modes.

The distinction explains permanence-in-change. Qualities belong to a substance as characteristic features, while modes are its variable manifestations. Jaina many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) depends on this structured complexity.

5. Which list contains exactly the five astikāyas?

A. Conscious soul (jīva), pudgala, dharma, adharma and ākāśa B. Conscious soul (jīva), pudgala, ākāśa, kāla and liberation (mokṣa) C. Pudgala, kāla, puṇya, pāpa and ākāśa D. Conscious soul (jīva), non-conscious reality (ajīva), influx of karmic matter (āsrava), bondage (bandha) and liberation (mokṣa)

Answer: A. Conscious soul (jīva), pudgala, dharma, adharma and ākāśa

These five are extended substances. Kāla completes the six-dravya scheme but not the pañcāstikāya scheme. The remaining distractors mix ontological substances with soteriological categories.

6. Dharma-dravya and adharmadravya respectively mean:

A. right conduct and wrong conduct. B. media enabling motion and rest. C. moral merit and moral demerit. D. activity and cessation of activity.

Answer: B. media enabling motion and rest.

They are enabling conditions, not forces that push or stop objects and not ethical merit or sin. The moral reading is a standard factual trap produced by the ordinary meanings of *dharma* and *adharmadravya*.

7. Which statement best expresses the Jain conception of conscious soul (jiva)?

A. It is ultimately identical with one universal Brahman. B. It is a temporary bundle of five aggregates. C. It is an individual conscious substance whose intrinsic capacities are obscured by action and moral consequence (karma). D. It is a property generated by a sufficiently organised body.

Answer: C. It is an individual conscious substance whose intrinsic capacities are obscured by action and moral consequence (karma).

Jainism affirms infinitely many beginningless conscious soul (jivas). Consciousness is intrinsic, not adventitious. Bondage obscures infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power without destroying the soul's numerical identity.

8. Which feature uniquely marks pudgala among the six substance (dravyas)?

A. It alone enables motion. B. It alone is not real. C. It alone is conscious. D. It alone possesses rūpa and includes karmic matter.

Answer: D. It alone possesses rūpa and includes karmic matter.

Pudgala is material, form-bearing, divisible and aggregative. Bodies, sense-objects and subtle karma-pudgala belong to it. This makes Jain bondage literally psychophysical rather than merely metaphorical.

9. In the strict Jain epistemological classification, ordinary sensory cognition is:

A. mediated cognition, though conventionally called empirical perception (pratyakṣa). B. rejected as intrinsically false. C. the highest form of unmediated perception (pratyakṣa). D. identical with perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna).

Answer: A. mediated cognition, though conventionally called empirical perception (pratyakṣa).

Strict directness is freedom from sense-and-mind mediation. Ordinary seeing is *sāṃvyaṭhārika perception* (*pratyakṣa*) in practical usage but falls under mediated mati-jñāna in the higher classification. This is the Jain "perception (pratyakṣa) inversion."

10. Which pair is correctly classified as parokṣa in the basic five-jñāna scheme?

A. Śruta and kevala B. Mati and śruta C. Avadhi and manāḥparyāya D. Mati and avadhi

Answer: B. Mati and śruta

Mati depends on senses and mind; śruta depends on signs, language and prior cognition. Avadhi, manāḥparyāya and kevala are direct in the strict sense because they transcend ordinary sensory-mental mediation.

11. Which is the correct ascending sequence of the five kinds of Jain knowledge?

A. Avadhi, mati, manāḥparyāya, śruta, kevala B. Mati, avadhi, śruta, kevala, manāḥparyāya C. Mati, śruta, avadhi, manāḥparyāya, kevala D. Śruta, mati, kevala, avadhi, manāḥparyāya

Answer: C. Mati, śruta, avadhi, manāḥparyāya, kevala

The sequence runs from ordinary sensory-mental cognition and verbal knowledge to limited clairvoyance, direct knowledge of others' mental modes and finally unlimited omniscience. It maps progressive removal of cognitive obstruction.

12. Which statement about Jain perception (pratyakṣa) is correct?

A. Kevala is indirect because it lacks sense-contact. B. Only sense-contact can generate direct knowledge. C. All five jñānas are equally direct. D. Avadhi, manāḥparyāya and kevala are strict or pāramāthika perception (pratyakṣa).

Answer: D. Avadhi, manāḥparyāya and kevala are strict or pāramāthika perception (pratyakṣa).

The Jain criterion is unmediated manifestation of the soul's cognition, not Nyāya-style sense-object contact. Avadhi and manāḥparyāya remain limited; only perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) is unlimited.

13. Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) is primarily the doctrine that:

A. reality is objectively many-sided and no finite unqualified proposition exhausts it. B. only linguistic differences generate plurality. C. reality is an indescribable illusion. D. every belief is equally true because truth is subjective.

Answer: A. reality is objectively many-sided and no finite unqualified proposition exhausts it.

Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) is first a metaphysical thesis, not a slogan of tolerance or scepticism. Multiple aspects belong to the object; finite cognition apprehends them partially. This objective basis separates Jaina perspectivism from subjectivism.

14. Standpoint analysis (nayavāda) explains:

A. the destruction of eight karmas. B. how partial standpoints can yield conditioned truths. C. the five ascetic vows. D. seven ontological substances.

Answer: B. how partial standpoints can yield conditioned truths.

A naya selects an aspect of a many-sided real. Partiality is not falsehood; error arises when a partial standpoint claims exhaustive status. Standpoint analysis (nayavāda) is thus epistemic, whereas many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) is ontological.

15. Qualified assertion (syādvāda) is best described as:

A. the taxonomy of seven epistemic standpoints. B. the denial that propositions can be true. C. conditional predication through the operator syāt. D. the doctrine that only omniscience is knowledge.

Answer: C. conditional predication through the operator syāt.

Syāt means “in some respect” or “from a certain standpoint.” It makes language register the conditions under which a proposition is true and prevents a finite assertion from becoming ekāntic or one-sided.

16. Which formula correctly distinguishes the three doctrines?

A. Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) = language; standpoint analysis (nayavāda) = matter; qualified assertion (syādvāda) = liberation. B. Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) = seven predicates; standpoint analysis (nayavāda) = seven principles (tattvas); qualified assertion (syādvāda) = seven vows. C. Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) = scepticism; standpoint analysis (nayavāda) = omniscience; qualified assertion (syādvāda) = ethics. D. Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) = many-sided reality; standpoint analysis (nayavāda) = standpoint-theory; qualified assertion (syādvāda) = qualified assertion.

Answer: D. Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) = many-sided reality; standpoint analysis (nayavāda) = standpoint-theory; qualified assertion (syādvāda) = qualified assertion.

The doctrines form a dependence chain rather than synonyms. Ontological complexity limits finite cognition to standpoints, and standpoint-conditioned cognition requires qualified language.

17. Which is the correct first member of the seven nayas?

A. Naigama naya B. Verbal testimony (śabda) naya C. Evambhūta naya D. Rjusūtra naya

Answer: A. Naigama naya

The seven nayas are naigama, saṃgraha, vyavahāra, rjusūtra, verbal testimony (śabda), samabhirūḍha and evambhūta. Naigama is the common, purposive or unspecialised practical standpoint.

18. Which option correctly pairs a naya with its characteristic emphasis?

A. Evambhūta-generic class-character B. Rjusūtra-the present-state or momentary standpoint C. Saṃgraha-only the present moment D. Vyavahāra-strict etymological derivation

Answer: B. Rjusūtra-the present-state or momentary standpoint

Saṃgraha stresses generic class-character; vyavahāra concerns practical particulars; samabhirūḍha is etymologically discriminating; evambhūta applies a word when its relevant function is actually being performed.

19. Which statement correctly distinguishes seven nayas from seven bhāngas?

A. Nayas apply only to monks, whereas bhāngas apply only to householders. B. Both are identical enumerations with different spellings. C. Nayas classify standpoints, whereas bhāngas classify conditioned predication forms. D. Nayas are karmic stages; bhāngas are forms of knowledge.

Answer: C. Nayas classify standpoints, whereas bhngas classify conditioned predication forms.

The seven nayas concern ways of approaching an object-generic, practical, temporal and linguistic. The seven bhngas are combinations of affirmation, negation and inexpressibility under *syāt*.

20. What is the correct fourth bhnga?

A. *syād asti ca avaktavyam* B. *syād asti ca nāsti ca* C. *syād nāsti* D. *syād avaktavyam*

Answer: D. *syād avaktavyam**

The sequence begins affirmation, negation, both, and then inexpressibility. The fifth, sixth and seventh combine *avaktavya* respectively with affirmation, negation, and both.

21. In sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī), avaktavya chiefly signifies:

A. the inability of one simple unqualified utterance to express complex indexed aspects simultaneously. B. that the object is absolutely unknowable. C. that silence itself causes liberation. D. that every proposition is meaningless.

Answer: A. the inability of one simple unqualified utterance to express complex indexed aspects simultaneously.

Inexpressibility is semantic-modal, not nihilistic or merely psychological. A thing can be knowable under distinct aspects even when their temporally or modally complex conjunction cannot be stated in one simple assertion.

22. "In some respect, the jar is and is not" avoids formal contradiction if:

A. one of the two predicates is secretly false. B. affirmation and negation are indexed to different respects, times, places or modes. C. the jar is treated as imaginary. D. both predicates are asserted without qualification at the same time.

Answer: B. affirmation and negation are indexed to different respects, times, places or modes.

The law of non-contradiction forbids P and not-P of the same subject in the same respect and time. Jaina predication deliberately changes the index; suppressing the index produces the caricature of contradiction.

23. The standard self-refutation objection to many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) argues that:

A. many-sided objects cannot have qualities. B. only a creator God can know all sides. C. if all claims are qualified, many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) must either qualify itself or violate its own rule. D. action and moral consequence (karma) cannot explain rebirth.

Answer: C. if all claims are qualified, many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) must either qualify itself or violate its own rule.

If unqualified, the doctrine appears absolutist; if qualified, critics say it loses universal force. The Jaina reply is reflexive qualification: the doctrine rejects finite one-sided exhaustiveness, not objective truth or graded comprehensiveness.

24. Which is the strongest Jaina reply to the claim that non-absolutism necessarily presupposes crude absolutism?

A. No proposition has any truth. B. Contradictions are always acceptable. C. Every standpoint is equally complete. D. Finite judgements are standpoint-bound, while perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) represents comprehensive cognition.

Answer: D. Finite judgements are standpoint-bound, while perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) represents comprehensive cognition.

Jainism distinguishes epistemic levels. It can affirm the objective many-sidedness of reality while denying that an ordinary unqualified claim exhausts it. The residual burden is independently supporting omniscience rather than merely postulating it to rescue the theory.

25. Which statement best captures Jaina action and moral consequence (karma)?

A. It is subtle material pudgala that binds the passion-affected soul. B. It is identical with Mīmāṃsā apūrva. C. It is divine reward and punishment. D. It is only the memory of previous actions.

Answer: A. It is subtle material pudgala that binds the passion-affected soul.

Jaina action and moral consequence (karma) is literally material, though extremely subtle. Psychic states attract and fix it to conscious soul (jīva). This differs from an unseen moral potency, a mere psychological disposition or a divine

ledger.

26. Which pair correctly distinguishes the two forms of bondage?

A. Bhāvabandha is bodily bondage; dravyabandha is verbal error. B. Bhāvabandha is psychic passion and delusion; dravyabandha is material karmic adhesion. C. Bhāvabandha is liberation; dravyabandha is omniscience. D. Bhāvabandha stops action and moral consequence (karma); dravyabandha sheds it.

Answer: B. Bhāvabandha is psychic passion and delusion; dravyabandha is material karmic adhesion.

Bhāvabandha is the internal causal condition that makes the soul adhesive. Dravyabandha is the objective karmic result. The distinction joins moral psychology to a realist material mechanism.

27. Which set gives the four parameters of bondage (bandha)?

A. Conscious soul (jīva), non-conscious reality (ajīva), puṇya and pāpa B. Influx of karmic matter (āsrava), bondage (bandha), shedding of karma (nirjarā) and liberation (mokṣa) C. Primordial material nature (prakṛti), sthiti, anubhāga and pradeśa D. Darśana, knowledge (jñāna), cāritra and tapas

Answer: C. Primordial material nature (prakṛti), sthiti, anubhāga and pradeśa

They denote the type, duration, intensity and quantity of karmic bondage. Yoga chiefly determines type and quantity; kaṣāya chiefly determines duration and intensity.

28. Which pairing of bondage parameter and principal determinant is correct?

A. Sthiti-yoga only; primordial material nature (prakṛti)-kaṣāya only B. Sthiti-ākāśa; pradeśa-kāla C. Primordial material nature (prakṛti)-perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna); anubhāga-liberation (mokṣa) D. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and pradeśa-yoga; sthiti and anubhāga-kaṣāya

Answer: D. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and pradeśa-yoga; sthiti and anubhāga-kaṣāya

Activity brings karmic matter into relation with the soul and affects its type and amount. Passions make bondage durable and intense. Hence intention and affect modify the karmic consequence of outwardly similar actions.

29. Which list gives the seven principles (tattvas)?

A. Conscious soul (jīva), non-conscious reality (ajīva), influx of karmic matter (āsrava), bondage (bandha), stoppage of karmic influx (saṁvara), shedding of karma (nirjarā) and liberation (mokṣa) B. Ahimsā, satya, asteya, brahmacharya, aparigraha, tapas and liberation (mokṣa) C. Conscious soul (jīva), pudgala, dharma, adharma, ākāśa, kāla and liberation (mokṣa) D. Mati, śruta, avadhi, manaḥparyāya, kevala, puṇya and pāpa

Answer: A. Conscious soul (jīva), non-conscious reality (ajīva), influx of karmic matter (āsrava), bondage (bandha), stoppage of karmic influx (saṁvara), shedding of karma (nirjarā) and liberation (mokṣa)

The list moves from the conscious and non-conscious poles to influx, binding, prevention, shedding and release. It is ontology organised for liberation rather than a neutral inventory.

30. The nine categories (padārthas) are:

A. the six substance (dravyas) plus the three jewels. B. the seven principles (tattvas) plus puṇya and pāpa. C. the five astikāyas plus four vows. D. the seven principles (tattvas) plus dharma and adharma.

Answer: B. the seven principles (tattvas) plus puṇya and pāpa.

The ninefold list makes moral valence explicit. Yet puṇya, though preferable to pāpa within cycle of rebirth (saṁsāra), still involves action and moral consequence (karma) and is not identical with liberation (mokṣa).

31. Which sequence correctly states the operational path from bondage to liberation?

A. Stoppage of karmic influx (saṁvara) -> influx of karmic matter (āsrava) -> bondage (bandha) -> liberation (mokṣa) -> shedding of karma (nirjarā) B. Bondage (bandha) -> liberation (mokṣa) -> influx of karmic matter (āsrava) -> stoppage of karmic influx (saṁvara) -> shedding of karma (nirjarā) C. Influx of karmic matter (āsrava) -> bondage (bandha) -> stoppage of karmic influx (saṁvara) -> shedding of karma (nirjarā) -> liberation (mokṣa) D. Shedding of karma (nirjarā) -> bondage (bandha) -> influx of karmic matter (āsrava) -> liberation (mokṣa) -> stoppage of karmic influx (saṁvara)

Answer: C. Influx of karmic matter (āsrava) -> bondage (bandha) -> stoppage of karmic influx (saṁvara) -> shedding of karma (nirjarā) -> liberation (mokṣa)

Influx of karmic matter (āsrava) is influx and bondage (bandha) is attachment. Stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) prevents new karmic inflow, while shedding of karma (nirjarā) removes accumulated action and moral consequence (karma). Liberation (mokṣa) follows only when karmic bondage is completely absent.

32. Which statement correctly distinguishes stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) and shedding of karma (nirjarā)?

A. Stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) is influx; shedding of karma (nirjarā) is adhesion. B. Stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) destroys the soul; shedding of karma (nirjarā) creates a new soul. C. Stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) produces merit; shedding of karma (nirjarā) produces demerit. D. Stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) stops new action and moral consequence (karma), whereas shedding of karma (nirjarā) sheds action and moral consequence (karma) already bound.

Answer: D. Stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) stops new action and moral consequence (karma), whereas shedding of karma (nirjarā) sheds action and moral consequence (karma) already bound.

The distinction expresses the preventive and purgative dimensions of Jaina practice. Closing an inlet does not remove sediment already deposited; both operations are required for liberation.

33. Which set contains only ghātiyā karmas?

A. Jñānāvaraṇīya, darśanāvaraṇīya, mohanīya and antarāya B. Vedanīya, nāma, gotra and āyus C. Mohanīya, nāma, gotra and āyus D. Jñānāvaraṇīya, vedanīya, nāma and gotra

Answer: A. Jñānāvaraṇīya, darśanāvaraṇīya, mohanīya and antarāya

These obstruct knowledge, perception, right orientation/conduct and energy. They damage or veil the soul's essential capacities. Mohanīya is especially dangerous because delusion corrupts both vision and conduct.

34. Which set contains only aghātiyā karmas?

A. Vedanīya, mohanīya, antarāya and āyus B. Vedanīya, nāma, gotra and āyus C. Nāma, gotra, jñānāvaraṇīya and darśanāvaraṇīya D. Jñānāvaraṇīya, darśanāvaraṇīya, mohanīya and antarāya

Answer: B. Vedanīya, nāma, gotra and āyus

They determine pleasure-pain, embodiment, status and lifespan without directly obscuring the soul's essential knowledge, perception, orientation and power. They remain after ghātiyā karmas are destroyed in the sayoga-kevalī.

35. Which stage correctly describes the sayoga-kevalī?

A. A liberated bodiless siddha beyond all activity B. A soul with false vision and no restraint C. An embodied omniscient arhat with activity and residual aghātiyā karmas D. A householder observing only partial vows

Answer: C. An embodied omniscient arhat with activity and residual aghātiyā karmas

Sayoga-kevalī is the thirteenth guṇasthāna. Ghātiyā karmas are destroyed, so omniscience manifests, but bodily, verbal and mental activity continues until the remaining embodiment-determining karmas approach exhaustion.

36. Ayoga-kevalī is:

A. the first stage of wrong vision. B. a condition of suppressed but undestroyed delusion. C. the stage where subtle greed alone remains. D. the final, momentary omniscient stage without activity immediately before siddhahood.

Answer: D. the final, momentary omniscient stage without activity immediately before siddhahood.

It is the fourteenth guṇasthāna. All yoga ceases; the remaining aghātiyā karmas are exhausted, after which the soul becomes a bodiless siddha. It should not be confused with final liberation itself.

37. The ratnatraya consists of:

A. Samyag-darśana, samyag-jñāna and samyak-cāritra B. Mati, śruta and kevala C. Influx of karmic matter (āsrava), stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) and shedding of karma (nirjarā) D. Ahimsā, satya and aparigraha

Answer: A. Samyag-darśana, samyag-jñāna and samyak-cāritra

Right vision, right knowledge and right conduct are mutually reinforcing dimensions of the path. Knowledge without conduct cannot halt karmic influx, while conduct without right orientation lacks soteriological direction.

38. Which is not one of the five mahāvratas?

A. Asteya B. Īśvara-praṇidhāna C. Aparigraha D. Ahimsā

Answer: B. Īśvara-praṇidhāna

The five are ahimsā, satya, asteya, brahmacarya and aparigraha. Devotion to a creator Lord is not included; Jainism is non-theistic regarding cosmic creation.

39. Which statement best explains “liberation by subtraction” in Jainism?

A. Liberation (mokṣa) creates consciousness in a previously unconscious soul. B. The soul is subtracted from existence. C. Removal of karmic obstruction manifests the soul’s intrinsic infinite capacities. D. Liberation adds divine grace to an incomplete conscious soul (jīva).

Answer: C. Removal of karmic obstruction manifests the soul’s intrinsic infinite capacities.

Perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) and the ananta-catuṣṭaya are revealed rather than manufactured. Purification radically changes the soul’s modes while preserving the numerical identity of the substance (dravya).

40. Which is the most defensible overall classification of Jaina philosophy?

A. Subjective idealism with ethical conventionalism B. Absolute monism with an illusory world C. Nihilism combined with linguistic scepticism D. Pluralistic realism combined with epistemic non-absolutism

Answer: D. Pluralistic realism combined with epistemic non-absolutism

Jainism affirms many independent substances, many souls and a mind-independent world. Finite knowledge is standpoint-conditioned, but the object is not made unreal by that limitation. This formulation also fits the 2025 “pluralistic and realistic” directive.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

41. Which statement about sallekhanā is doctrinally safest?

A. It is a carefully regulated, passionless thinning of body and attachment at an appropriate end of life, not impulsive suicide. B. It is a sacrifice offered to a creator God. C. It aims to destroy the soul along with the body. D. It is mandatory self-killing for every lay follower.

Answer: A. It is a carefully regulated, passionless thinning of body and attachment at an appropriate end of life, not impulsive suicide.

The decisive factors are intention, terminal context, equanimity and absence of passion. It must not be romanticised or treated as an ordinary escape from distress; its doctrinal defence rests on non-attachment and karmic purification.

42. Śaṅkara’s central criticism of many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) is that:

A. material action and moral consequence (karma) requires a creator God. B. opposed predicates threaten contradiction and the doctrine faces a self-reference dilemma. C. liberation cannot preserve individuality. D. Jainism accepts too few substances.

Answer: B. opposed predicates threaten contradiction and the doctrine faces a self-reference dilemma.

Śaṅkara presses both logical consistency and assertoric force: if many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) is absolute, it violates itself; if merely conditional, it may fail to govern discourse. Jainism replies through indexed predicates and reflexive qualification.

43. Which named criticism-reply pair is correctly matched?

A. Rāmānuja: no object has qualities; reply: momentariness B. Cārvāka: a permanent soul cannot act; reply: apūrva C. Dharmakīrti/Buddhist: a permanent-yet-changing soul faces the causal-efficacy dilemma; reply: permanence as substance (dravya) and change as mode (pariyāya) D. Nyāya: all objects are empty; reply: dependent origination

Answer: C. Dharmakīrti/Buddhist: a permanent-yet-changing soul faces the causal-efficacy dilemma; reply: permanence as substance (dravya) and change as mode (pariyāya)

The Jaina response invokes *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya*. Its force depends on accepting a real substance-mode distinction; a Buddhist who denies enduring substance will remain unconvinced.

44. What is the strongest residual philosophical difficulty in the doctrine of material action and moral consequence (karma)?

A. It requires an eternal creator. B. It makes ethical conduct irrelevant. C. It cannot distinguish good and bad actions. D. The interaction between conscious soul (jīva) and material karma-pudgala remains obscure.

Answer: D. The interaction between conscious soul (jīva) and material karma-pudgala remains obscure.

Jainism invokes the conscious soul (jīva)'s pradeśas, embodiment and passion-generated adhesiveness, but critics argue that the causal bridge still requires explanation. A strong answer should present the internal mechanism and preserve this residual objection.

45. In a PYQ asking “How does action and moral consequence (karma) bear upon soteriology?”, which answer-plan best follows the directive?

A. Define material action and moral consequence (karma), trace influx of karmic matter (āsrava)-bondage (bandha)-stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara)-shedding of karma (nirjarā)-liberation (mokṣa), connect practices to each stage, then evaluate the mechanism. B. Compare every Indian school without explaining Jaina action and moral consequence (karma). C. Discuss only the seven nayas and omit liberation. D. Narrate Mahāvīra's life and list pilgrimage centres.

Answer: A. Define material action and moral consequence (karma), trace influx of karmic matter (āsrava)-bondage (bandha)-stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara)-shedding of karma (nirjarā)-liberation (mokṣa), connect practices to each stage, then evaluate the mechanism.

“Bear upon” tests causal dependence, not independent notes on action and moral consequence (karma) and liberation (mokṣa). The answer must show how the ontology of karmic matter determines both the disciplines of prevention/shedding and the final condition of the soul.

46. Which statement is a factual trap?

A. Puṇya and pāpa are added to seven principles (tattvas) in the nine-padārtha list. B. Puṇya is identical with liberation (mokṣa) because all good action and moral consequence (karma) liberates permanently. C. Both puṇya and pāpa involve karmic determination. D. Puṇya may improve one's saṃsāric condition.

Answer: B. Puṇya is identical with liberation (mokṣa) because all good action and moral consequence (karma) liberates permanently.

Merit is preferable to demerit but remains karmic involvement and can yield favourable rebirth rather than final release. Liberation (mokṣa) requires transcendence of all action and moral consequence (karma), pleasant as well as painful.

47. Which statement about the fourteen guṇasthānas is correct?

A. They describe cosmological substances rather than spiritual development. B. Every stage is attained at the instant of right vision. C. They mark graded purification from mithyā-dṛṣṭi through sayoga- and ayoga-kevalī toward liberation. D. They are seven linguistic standpoints doubled.

Answer: C. They mark graded purification from mithyā-dṛṣṭi through sayoga- and ayoga-kevalī toward liberation.

The scheme makes spiritual progress gradual and karmically analysable. Delusion may be suppressed at stage eleven and destroyed at stage twelve; omniscience with activity appears at thirteen and without activity at fourteen.

48. Which concluding sentence best answers “Is Jaina philosophy pluralistic and realistic? Critically discuss”?

A. Jainism is realistic only about matter, not souls or modes. B. Jainism is monistic because all liberated souls merge. C. Jainism is relativist, so it denies every objective object. D. Jainism is pluralistic realism with standpoint-conditioned finite knowledge, though substance-mode unity and omniscience remain contested.

Answer: D. Jainism is pluralistic realism with standpoint-conditioned finite knowledge, though substance-mode unity and omniscience remain contested.

The sentence answers both classificatory terms, distinguishes ontology from epistemology and preserves a critical remainder. It avoids the false inference that qualified judgement entails idealism or scepticism.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 9 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

The following are independent practice models prepared from the verified question corpus and Jaina doctrine. They are not official UPSC answer keys.

2018 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

Question: How do the Jaina philosophers explain 'bondage'? What, according to them, is the distinction between 'liberated soul' and 'bound soul'? What do the Jainas think about the condition of the 'liberated soul'? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- Explain the mechanism of bondage, not merely define action and moral consequence (karma).
- Compare the bound and liberated soul on identity, embodiment, cognition and destiny.
- State positively what remains after liberation.
- "Discuss" requires one conceptual difficulty and a balanced conclusion.

Independent model answer

Jainism explains bondage as the beginningless but terminable association of conscious **conscious soul (jīva)** with subtle material **karma-pudgala**. The soul is intrinsically capable of infinite knowledge, perception, energy and bliss, yet activity of body, speech and mind (**yoga**), when coloured by delusion and the passions of anger, pride, deceit and greed, attracts karmic matter.

Bondage has two inseparable dimensions. **Bhāvabandha** is psychic bondage: the soul's wrong vision, attachment, aversion and passion make it "adhesive." **Dravyabandha** is the consequent material attachment of karmic particles. The process may be mapped as **influx of karmic matter (āsrava)** (influx) -> **bondage (bandha)** (adhesion). Its reversal requires **stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara)**, which stops fresh influx, and **shedding of karma (nirjarā)**, which sheds accumulated action and moral consequence (karma).

Bound soul	Liberated soul
Embodied and co-extensive with its body	Bodiless siddha
Knowledge and perception obscured	Perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) and perfect perception manifest
Subject to pleasure, pain, birth and death	Beyond suffering and rebirth
Conditioned by all eight karma-prakṛtis	Entirely free from karmic matter
Moves through cycle of rebirth (saṃsāra)	Abides at siddha-śīlā

The liberated soul does not merge into Brahman and is not annihilated. It retains numerical individuality while manifesting the **ananta-catuṣṭaya**-infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power. Liberation is thus purification of an enduring individual, achieved through the ratnatraya of right vision, right knowledge and right conduct.

The theory preserves moral agency and personal continuity without a creator God. Its residual difficulty is explaining how conscious soul (jīva) and material action and moral consequence (karma) interact. Nevertheless, within Jaina pluralistic realism, bondage is a real psychophysical entanglement and liberation (mokṣa) its complete removal.

Why this earns marks

- Answers all three limbs of the question in separate, connected moves.
- Distinguishes bhāvabandha from dravyabandha instead of treating bondage generically.
- Uses the complete influx of karmic matter (āsrava)-bondage (bandha)-stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara)-shedding of karma (nirjarā) route.
- Compares bound and liberated souls across five examinable dimensions.
- Avoids the Advaita trap of merger and the Buddhist trap of self-extinction.

- Adds a precise interaction objection without displacing doctrinal exposition.

2019 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: How is reality defined by the Jainas? How is this theory of reality reflected in their view on judgements? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- Define reality through the Jaina formula of permanence-in-change.
- Explain substance (dravya), quality (guṇa), mode (paryāya) and many-sided reality (anekāntavāda).
- Derive standpoint analysis (nayavāda), qualified assertion (syādvāda) and sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) from that ontology.
- “Discuss” requires illustration, criticism, reply and a qualified verdict.

Independent model answer

Jainism defines the real as that which possesses **utpāda** (origination), **vyaya** (decay) and **dhrauvya** (persistence): *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya-yuktaṃ sat*. Pure permanence cannot explain experienced change, while pure flux cannot explain identity. A real therefore persists as **substance (dravya)**, possesses abiding **qualities (guṇas)**, and changes through **paryāyas**.

This ontology is irreducibly plural. The six substance (dravyas) are conscious soul (jīva), pudgala, dharma, adharma, ākāśa and kāla. Five are astikāyas; kāla is a substance (dravya) but not an astikāya. A gold ornament illustrates the formula: gold persists, bracelet-mode ceases and ring-mode originates. Because every real contains multiple objective aspects, reality is **many-sided reality (anekāntavāda)**, non-one-sided.

The theory of judgement follows from this metaphysics. Finite knowers normally apprehend an object under a partial **naya** or standpoint. A naya is not false merely because partial; it becomes false when absolutised. **Qualified assertion (syādvāda)** therefore requires the operator *syāt*—“in some respect”—so that language records the conditions of truth. Its sevenfold elaboration is:

1. *syād asti*—in some respect it is;
2. *syād nāsti*—in some respect it is not;
3. *syād asti ca nāsti ca*—in different respects it is and is not;
4. *syād avaktavyam*—in some respect it is inexpressible;
5. *syād asti ca avaktavyam*;
6. *syād nāsti ca avaktavyam*;
7. *syād asti ca nāsti ca avaktavyam*.

A jar exists here and now as a jar, does not exist as cloth or as a future destroyed jar, and is *avaktavya* when temporally and modally distinct determinations are demanded in one simple, simultaneous utterance. The scheme does not affirm P and not-P in the same respect, place, time and mode.

Śaṃkara objects that opposed predicates destroy determinate knowledge and that many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) either asserts itself absolutely or loses universal force. The Jaina reply indexes predication to **substance (dravya)**, **kṣetra**, **kāla** and **bhāva** and reflexively applies *syāt* to its own doctrine. Moreover, finite judgement is standpoint-bound, whereas perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) is comprehensive.

Thus Jaina judgement is not scepticism or subjective relativism. It is the linguistic discipline demanded by a pluralistic realism. Its strength is the reconciliation of identity, change and cognitive humility; its burden is independently justifying omniscience and the status of its own universal claims.

Why this earns marks

- Opens with the exact metaphysical formula and explains each term.
- Links substance (dravya)-quality (guṇa)-mode (paryāya) to many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) rather than listing doctrines.
- Derives judgement theory through the chain many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) -> naya -> syāt -> seven bhaṅgas.
- Gives all seven predications in the correct order.

- Uses a worked object-example and the conditions blocking contradiction.
- Engages Śaṃkara and ends with a genuinely critical verdict.

2020 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: Examine the concept of Karma according to Jainism. How does it bear upon their conception of Liberation?

Demand decoding

- Identify what is distinctive about Jaina action and moral consequence (karma).
- Show its causal relation to bondage and liberation.
- “Examine” requires a compact conceptual assessment, not only description.

Independent model answer

Jainism treats action and moral consequence (karma) not merely as moral law, merit-demerit or unseen potency, but as subtle **material pudgala**. Activity of body, speech and mind produces **influx of karmic matter (āsrava)**, while delusion and the four **kaṣāyas**-anger, pride, deceit and greed-make the soul receptive to karmic matter. Its attachment is **bondage (bandha)**, which obscures the conscious soul (jīva)’s intrinsic knowledge, perception, energy and bliss.

This material conception directly structures liberation. The ratnatraya-right vision, right knowledge and right conduct-together with vows, restraint and austerity weakens passion. **Stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara)** prevents fresh influx; **shedding of karma (nirjarā)** exhausts previously accumulated action and moral consequence (karma). Destruction of the obscuring karmas manifests perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna), and destruction of every karmic residue yields liberation (mokṣa): the individual soul becomes a bodiless siddha.

Hence liberation is “by subtraction”: perfection is revealed when obstruction is removed, not bestowed by God or produced as a new essence. The doctrine unifies ethics and metaphysics through a precise causal mechanism. However, the interaction of material action and moral consequence (karma) with conscious soul (jīva) remains philosophically obscure, and beginningless bondage explains the absence of a first fall rather than its possibility.

Why this earns marks

- Identifies action and moral consequence (karma) as material pudgala, the central factual discriminator.
- Connects yoga and kaṣāya to influx and adhesion.
- Explains both preventive and purgative sides of liberation.
- Uses the “liberation by subtraction” insight to answer “bear upon.”
- Includes one concise internal strength and one residual objection.

2021 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the Jaina view of seven-fold (sapta-bhaṅgī) ‘Naya’.

Demand decoding

- Clarify the relation among naya, syāt and sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī).
- State all seven predications exactly and in order.
- Explain *avaktavya* and answer the contradiction objection.

Independent model answer

The Jaina sevenfold judgement is the formal expression of a many-sided reality. **Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda)** is the metaphysical thesis that a real has multiple aspects; **standpoint analysis (nayavāda)** explains that finite cognition approaches it through partial standpoints; **qualified assertion (syādvāda)** requires each finite assertion to be qualified by *syāt*, “in some respect.” Sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) is therefore not a list of seven nayas but a schema of seven conditioned predications.

1. **syād asti**-in some respect, it is.
2. **syād nāsti**-in some respect, it is not.
3. **syād asti ca nāsti ca**-in different respects or successively, it is and is not.
4. **syād avaktavyam**-in some respect, it is inexpressible.

5. **syād asti ca avaktavyam**-it is and is inexpressible.
6. **syād nāsti ca avaktavyam**-it is not and is inexpressible.
7. **syād asti ca nāsti ca avaktavyam**-it is, is not and is inexpressible.

A jar exists as a present jar at a given place; it does not exist as cloth, elsewhere, or after destruction. It may be called inexpressible where a single unqualified utterance is asked to express jointly what belongs to different times, modes or relations. *Avaktavya* therefore does not mean sheer ignorance or mystical silence; it marks a limitation of simple simultaneous predication.

Critics such as Śaṅkara and Rāmānuja argue that “is” and “is not” threaten non-contradiction. The Jaina reply is that contradiction arises only when opposed predicates attach in the same respect, place, time and mode. *Syāt* expressly prevents that collapse.

Sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) is consequently neither seven truth-values nor unrestricted relativism. It is a discipline for expressing objective but aspect-conditioned truths. Its success depends, however, on making the relevant qualifications explicit rather than using *syāt* as a merely decorative hedge.

Why this earns marks

- Separates the seven standpoints from the seven predication forms.
- Reproduces all seven bhaṅgas accurately and sequentially.
- Gives *avaktavya* a semantic-modal, not mystical, meaning.
- Applies the doctrine to a single coherent example.
- Presents the named contradiction criticism and the indexed Jaina reply.

2022 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: How does Jaina view of Karma bear upon their soteriology? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Focus on how the action and moral consequence (karma) doctrine determines the path and goal.
- Link material action and moral consequence (karma) to ethical discipline and liberation.
- “Critically discuss” requires a balanced evaluative close.

Independent model answer

Jaina soteriology is unintelligible without its distinctive doctrine of action and moral consequence (karma) as subtle **pudgala**. The conscious soul (jīva) is intrinsically capable of infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and power, but passion-coloured activity attracts karmic particles that obscure these capacities. Bondage is thus real material accretion, not merely guilt, memory or divine punishment.

The path directly reverses this mechanism: **influx of karmic matter (āsrava) -> bondage (bandha) -> stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) -> shedding of karma (nirjarā) -> liberation (mokṣa)**. The three jewels orient the whole person; ahiṃsā, restraint and the vows reduce the activities and passions causing influx; austerity and equanimity shed old action and moral consequence (karma). When ghātiyā karmas are destroyed, perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) manifests in the embodied sayoga-kevalī; after the remaining aghātiyā karmas expire, the soul becomes an unembodied siddha.

The view powerfully integrates moral intention, conduct, cognition and embodiment without invoking creator-God or grace. Yet its literal materialism generates an interaction problem: how does conscious soul (jīva) attract and carry karmic matter? Therefore action and moral consequence (karma) gives Jaina soteriology exceptional causal precision, but at a significant metaphysical cost.

Why this earns marks

- Directly answers “bear upon” through a mechanism rather than a definition.
- Correctly distinguishes the kevalin stage from final siddhahood.
- Integrates ratnatraya, vows, stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) and shedding of karma (nirjarā).
- Shows why the theory works without a creator God.
- Ends with a focused consciousness-matter criticism.

2022 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: 'The doctrine of Relativism of Jain Philosophy cannot be logically sustained without postulating 'Absolutism'.' Critically examine this view and give reasons in the favour of your answer.

Demand decoding

- Reconstruct the self-reference and universal-scope objection fairly.
- Test whether Jainism is crude relativism or realist non-absolutism.
- Give explicit reasons for a defended conclusion.

Independent model answer

The objection identifies a reflexive difficulty. If every proposition is only relatively true, then "every proposition is relative" is itself relative and cannot govern all judgements. If Jainism asserts many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) universally, it appears to make an absolute exception for itself. Further, doctrines such as real substance (dravyas), the soul's intrinsic consciousness and perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) seem to claim more than local validity.

This criticism defeats the slogan "all views are equally true," but that slogan is not classical Jainism. Jainism is a **realist non-absolutism**. Objects possess determinate, objective aspects; a *naya* is true when it tracks one such aspect and false when its partial truth is absolutised. *Syāt* indexes truth to substance, place, time and mode; it does not turn truth into subjective preference.

Jainism can also distinguish finite and perfect cognition. Ordinary knowledge is karmically limited and therefore aspectual. **Perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna)**, attained when cognitive obstructions are destroyed, apprehends all aspects. The minimum unconditional commitment is not "nothing is absolute," but "no finite, unqualified standpoint exhausts a many-sided real." This proposition can itself be reflexively qualified without becoming meaningless: from the standpoint of finite discourse, non-one-sided predication is rationally required.

Nevertheless, some absoluteness remains. The claim that reality has substance, qualities and modes is universal, while the postulate of omniscience requires independent defence. If invoked solely to guarantee the system, it risks circularity.

Therefore Jaina relativism cannot survive as total relativism; nor need it. The coherent doctrine is qualified pluralistic realism: objective reality, graded cognition and anti-absolutism concerning finite predication. It concedes a minimal framework of truth while rejecting one-sided claims to exhaustive truth.

Why this earns marks

- States the self-reference objection in its strongest logical form.
- Distinguishes relativism, non-absolutism and objective standpoint-truth.
- Explains how perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) functions in the Jaina reply.
- Concedes the universal commitments and evidential burden instead of offering a defensive answer.
- Gives clear reasons for a nuanced verdict rather than a binary yes/no.

2023 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: "All human knowledge is empirical and therefore relative." Critically examine Jaina theory of sevenfold judgement (saptabhaṅginaya) in the light of above statement.

Demand decoding

- Evaluate, rather than simply accept, the quotation.
- Relate the Jaina classification of knowledge to sevenfold judgement.
- State the scope and limit of sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) concisely.

Independent model answer

Jainism agrees that ordinary embodied cognition is limited, but it does not accept that all knowledge is merely sensory-empirical. In its fivefold classification, **mati** and **śruta** are mediated or *parokṣa* knowledge. **Avadhi**, **manaḥparyāya** and **kevala** are direct in the strict Jaina sense because they are not mediated by ordinary senses and mind. Thus the proposition in the question is only partially Jaina.

Sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) governs finite discursive judgement. A real combines enduring substance (dravya) and changing paryāyas; consequently a jar may be affirmed with respect to its own substance, place, time and mode, negated with respect to another, and called *avaktavya* when these indexed determinations cannot be expressed together in one simple utterance. The seven combinations of affirmation, negation and inexpressibility prevent a partial judgement from claiming exhaustive truth.

Yet relativity is not universal scepticism. Nayas disclose objective aspects, and perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) is held to be complete and non-relative. Critics may regard omniscience as an ad hoc exception; Jainism replies that it follows from removal of knowledge-obscuring action and moral consequence (karma).

Hence sevenfold judgement is a discipline for finite, conditioned assertion, not proof that every possible cognition is empirical or equally relative.

Why this earns marks

- Challenges the quotation through the Jaina perception (pratyakṣa)/parokṣa inversion.
- Correctly classifies all five jñānas.
- Explains the function of sevenfold judgement without wasting space listing all seven.
- Distinguishes objective partial truth from scepticism.
- Adds the precise perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) objection and reply.

2024 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

Question: What is the distinction between Bhāva-bandha and Dravya-bandha, according to the Jainas? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- Define both forms of bondage with doctrinal precision.
- Explain their causal relation and their place in the liberation sequence.
- “Discuss” warrants the four bondage (bandha) parameters and one critical issue.

Independent model answer

Jainism distinguishes the soul’s psychic condition from the material result produced by it. **Bhāva-bandha** is the bondage constituted by wrong vision, ignorance, attachment, aversion and the four kaṣāyas—anger, pride, deceit and greed. It is a modification of the conscious soul (jīva) that makes it receptive or “sticky.” **Dravya-bandha** is the actual association of subtle karma-pudgala with the soul.

The relation is causal:

mithyātva + yoga + kaṣāya → bhāva-bandha → influx of karmic matter (āsrava) → dravya-bandha

Yoga, activity of body, speech and mind, brings karmic matter into relation with the soul. Passion fixes it deeply. Material bondage is further analysed through four parameters: **primordial material nature (prakṛti)** (type), **sthiti** (duration), **anubhāga/rasa** (intensity) and **pradeśa** (quantity). Yoga chiefly determines type and quantity; kaṣāya chiefly determines duration and intensity. Thus identical outward acts can have different karmic consequences according to inner passion.

The distinction also clarifies liberation. Right vision and passionless conduct transform the psychic condition and produce **stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara)**, stopping new influx. Austerity and equanimity promote **shedding of karma (nirjarā)**, the shedding of already bound material action and moral consequence (karma). Inner reform and material purification are therefore mutually necessary.

The theory avoids reducing bondage either to intention alone or to a mechanical physical event. However, it leaves a category-crossing difficulty: the causal bridge by which a conscious modification attracts material particles is asserted more clearly than it is explained.

Why this earns marks

- Defines both terms and avoids reversing psychic cause and material result.
- Supplies a clear causal chain from mithyātva and passion to material adhesion.
- Adds the four parameters of bondage (bandha) with their determinants.
- Shows how the distinction maps onto stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) and shedding of karma (nirjarā).

- Gives a balanced assessment of the doctrine's explanatory gain and interaction problem.

2025 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Question: Is Jaina philosophy pluralistic and realistic? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Establish pluralism and realism separately with doctrinal evidence.
- Reconcile objective reality with standpoint-conditioned knowledge.
- Critically discuss objections to permanence-in-change and qualified predication.

Independent model answer

Jaina philosophy is **pluralistic** because it recognises infinitely many individual conscious soul (jīvas) and five irreducible kinds of non-conscious reality (ajīva), together forming six substance (dravyas): conscious soul (jīva), pudgala, dharma, adharma, ākāśa and kāla. It rejects both a single universal self and reduction of consciousness to matter. Liberation too preserves a plurality of individual siddhas.

It is **realistic** because substances, qualities and modes exist independently of their being known. The external world is neither mental construction nor ultimately illusory. Each real possesses persistence as substance (dravya) and change through mode (paryāya); hence *sat* includes origination, decay and permanence. Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) means that the object itself is many-sided, not merely that observers invent different descriptions.

Its epistemology qualifies, rather than abandons, realism. Nayas select objective aspects; qualified assertion (syādvāda) indexes assertions to respect, place, time and mode; sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) systematically combines affirmation, negation and inexpressibility. Truth is perspective-conditioned for finite knowers but not merely subjective.

Three objections remain. Śaṅkara argues that opposed predicates threaten non-contradiction; the Jaina reply separates their respects. A Buddhist critic rejects the enduring substance beneath changing modes; Jainism invokes *utpāda-vyaya-dhruvya*. The self-refutation objection asks whether many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) absolutises its own relativity; Jainism reflexively qualifies finite discourse and reserves comprehensive cognition for perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna).

Therefore Jainism is best described as **pluralistic realism with epistemic non-absolutism**. Its ontology is robustly objective and irreducibly many; its principal burdens are defending the substance-mode distinction and independently grounding omniscience.

Why this earns marks

- Proves pluralism through many souls, six substance (dravyas) and non-merger in liberation.
- Proves realism through mind-independent substance (dravya)-quality (guṇa)-mode (paryāya).
- Explains why epistemic qualification does not entail ontological idealism.
- Uses three distinct criticisms with their Jaina replies.
- Ends with the most precise classificatory formula and its residual burdens.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish many-sided reality (anekāntavāda), standpoint analysis (nayavāda) and qualified assertion (syādvāda), and show why they cannot be treated as synonyms.

Demand decoding

- Define each doctrine at its proper philosophical level.
- Establish their order of dependence.
- Use one example to show their coordinated operation.

Full answer

The three doctrines form a connected architecture, not three names for relativism. **Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda)** is metaphysical: every real has multiple objective aspects because substance (dravya) persists while qualities (guṇas) and paryāyas provide complex, changing determinations. No finite unqualified proposition exhausts

such a real.

Standpoint analysis (nayavāda) is epistemic. A finite knower approaches the many-sided object under a **naya**, a partial standpoint. The substantial standpoint may stress persistence, the modal standpoint change, and practical or linguistic standpoints other features. Partiality is legitimate; only its absolutisation becomes ekāntavāda.

Qualified assertion (syādvāda) is semantic-logical. Since a standpoint yields conditioned truth, assertion should bear *syāt*—"in some respect." This qualification is developed into sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī).

A gold bracelet makes the sequence clear. The real includes enduring gold and changing bracelet-mode. One standpoint stresses material continuity, another the produced form. "It exists" is true as this bracelet now; "it does not exist" is true as a ring or after remaking.

Thus ontology grounds standpoint, and standpoint grounds qualified speech. Treating the doctrines as synonyms erases Jainism's movement from reality to knowledge to language.

Why this earns marks

- Defines all three doctrines without conceptual overlap.
- Shows the dependence chain explicitly.
- Uses substance (dravya) and mode (paryāya) to ground the explanation.
- Applies one example across all levels.
- Ends by identifying the precise consequence of conflation.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Why is the Jaina classification of perception (pratyakṣa) described as an "inversion" of ordinary epistemological usage? Examine.

Demand decoding

- State the strict Jaina criterion of directness.
- Classify the five jñānas correctly.
- Explain the philosophical function and one objection.

Full answer

Ordinary usage treats sense-perception as paradigmatically direct. Jainism "inverts" this expectation because strict **perception (pratyakṣa)** means cognition manifested by the soul without mediation by senses or mind. Seeing a jar is only **sāmvyavahārika perception (pratyakṣa)**, conventionally direct for practical purposes; doctrinally it belongs to mediated **mati-jñāna**.

The five jñānas reflect this criterion. **Mati** and **śruta** are parokṣa because they depend respectively on sensory-mental processes and signs or testimony. **Avadhi** is limited direct knowledge of material things beyond ordinary sensory range; **manaḥparyāya** directly grasps others' mental modes; **perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna)** is unlimited, unmediated omniscience.

The classification links epistemology to soteriology. Directness increases as knowledge-obscuring action and moral consequence (karma) is removed, culminating in the soul's intrinsic cognition. It also explains why ordinary human judgements require standpoint analysis (nayavāda) and qualified assertion (syādvāda).

Nyāya may object that knowledge without sense-contact is not perceptual, while the higher jñānas lack ordinary verification. Jainism replies that metaphysical directness concerns absence of mediation, though the empirical objection to extraordinary cognition remains.

Why this earns marks

- Identifies the exact criterion causing the inversion.
- Correctly classifies all five forms of knowledge.
- Links epistemology to karmic purification and conditional judgement.
- Introduces a named Nyāya objection.
- Gives a qualified rather than dogmatic conclusion.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Does sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) violate the law of non-contradiction? Critically examine.

Demand decoding

- State the logical test for contradiction.
- Examine the third and *avaktavya*-bearing bhangas.
- Present the classical objection, Jaina reply and residual condition of success.

Full answer

The law of non-contradiction prohibits asserting P and not-P of the same subject in the same respect, time and sense. Sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) does not intend such an assertion. It combines affirmation, negation and inexpressibility under the operator *syāt*, which indexes every claim to a standpoint.

The first two bhangas-*syād asti* and *syād nāsti*-affirm and deny under different conditions. A jar exists as this jar here and now; it does not exist as cloth, elsewhere, or after destruction. The third-*syād asti ca nāsti ca*-combines these judgements successively or under distinct respects, not as an unqualified simultaneous contradiction.

The fourth, *syād avaktavyam*, marks the inability of one simple utterance to express jointly a complex of differently indexed aspects. It does not mean that the object is unknowable. The remaining bhangas combine *avaktavya* with affirmation, negation, and both.

Śaṃkara and Rāmānuja object that if opposed attributes are genuinely real, shifting the standpoint only relocates rather than solves contradiction. The Jaina response invokes substance (dravya)-mode (paryāya): permanence belongs to the continuing substance, while origination and cessation belong to modes. The object is complex, but no identical predicate is both affirmed and denied under one index.

A further self-reference problem remains. If every assertion must be qualified, the sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) doctrine itself must be qualified. Jainism can accept this reflexively; it rejects finite one-sided exhaustiveness, not all determinate truth.

Therefore sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) is compatible with non-contradiction when indexes of substance, place, time and mode are explicit. It becomes incoherent only when *syāt* is reduced to a vague verbal hedge or opposed claims are made under the same conditions.

Why this earns marks

- Begins with the formal condition for contradiction.
- Tests the most vulnerable third and fourth predications.
- Explains *avaktavya* with semantic precision.
- Names Śaṃkara and Rāmānuja and supplies the substance (dravya)-mode (paryāya) reply.
- Adds the self-reference issue and a conditional verdict.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Explain how the eight karma-prakṛtis and four parameters of bondage (bandha) deepen the Jaina account of moral responsibility.

Demand decoding

- Classify all eight karmas and state their functions.
- Explain the four dimensions of karmic binding and their determinants.
- Derive the account of responsibility from intention, passion and activity.

Full answer

Jainism deepens moral responsibility by treating action and moral consequence (karma) as subtle matter whose type and force vary with the agent's activity and passions. The eight **karma-prakṛtis** divide into two groups. The **ghātiyā** karmas are jñānāvaraṇīya, obscuring knowledge; darśanāvaraṇīya, obscuring perception; mohaniya, deluding vision and conduct; and antārāya, obstructing energy. The **aghātiyā** karmas are vedanīya, determining pleasure and pain; nāma, embodiment; gotra, status; and āyus, lifespan.

This taxonomy explains different dimensions of empirical limitation rather than attributing every consequence to an undifferentiated moral force. Mohanīya is especially decisive because delusion misorients both belief and conduct. Destruction of the four ghātiyā karmas yields the omniscient but embodied sayoga-kevalī; the aghātiyā karmas expire only before final siddhahood.

Each act also binds action and moral consequence (karma) under four parameters: **primordial material nature (prakṛti)** or type, **sthiti** or duration, **anubhāga** or intensity, and **pradeśa** or quantity. Yoga-the activity of body, speech and mind-chiefly determines type and quantity. Kaṣāya-anger, pride, deceit and greed-chiefly determines duration and intensity. Passionless activity therefore has a different karmic result from outwardly similar passion-coloured activity.

The framework joins external conduct to inner agency. It avoids reducing responsibility either to intention alone or to physical movement alone: action brings action and moral consequence (karma), while passion fixes it. Its strength is causal and ethical granularity. Its weakness is metaphysical elaborateness and the obscure interaction between conscious states and material particles.

Thus Jaina responsibility is neither divine judgement nor mechanical behaviourism. It is a psychophysical account in which what one does and how one inwardly does it jointly shape bondage.

Why this earns marks

- Names and correctly classifies all eight karma-prakṛtis.
- Explains rather than merely lists what each class does.
- Gives all four bondage (bandha) parameters and their principal determinants.
- Derives a nuanced account of intention and action.
- Connects sayoga-kevalī to the ghātiyā/aghātiyā distinction.
- Balances explanatory richness against metaphysical cost.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: “Jaina liberation is purification in substance but transformation in mode.” Analyse.

Demand decoding

- Interpret both halves through substance (dravya)-mode (paryāya) ontology.
- Reconstruct bondage, the path, perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) and final liberation (mokṣa).
- Explain continuity and change in the soul, with criticisms and a reasoned verdict.

Full answer

The statement applies Jaina ontology directly to soteriology. A real combines persistence and change: substance (dravya) endures while paryāyas originate and cease. The conscious soul (jīva) therefore remains numerically the same substance through bondage and liberation, yet its modes and existential condition are radically transformed.

Purification is “in substance” because liberation does not manufacture a new self or merge many selves into one. Every conscious soul (jīva) is intrinsically endowed with infinite knowledge, perception, power and bliss. Empirical ignorance arises because subtle material action and moral consequence (karma) obscures these capacities. Removing action and moral consequence (karma) reveals what belongs to the soul; it does not replace its identity. In this sense liberation (mokṣa) is liberation by subtraction.

The process begins with passion-coloured yoga. Wrong vision and kaṣāya constitute bhāvabandha; karmic influx and adhesion constitute dravyabandha. The sequence is **influx of karmic matter (āsrava) -> bondage (bandha) -> stoppage of karmic influx (saṃvara) -> shedding of karma (nirjarā) -> liberation (mokṣa)**. Right vision, right knowledge and right conduct provide orientation; the vows reduce harmful activity and attachment; austerity and equanimity shed old action and moral consequence (karma).

Transformation is nevertheless real at the level of modes. The bound conscious soul (jīva) is embodied, contracts or expands with its body, undergoes pleasure and pain and moves through rebirth. Progress through the fourteen guṇasthānas gradually removes delusion and passion. At stage thirteen, the sayoga-kevalī has destroyed the ghātiyā karmas and manifests omniscience while residual aghātiyā karmas sustain embodiment. At stage fourteen, activity ceases; after the remaining action and moral consequence (karma) is exhausted, the bodiless siddha abides at siddha-śīlā, beyond rebirth.

The theory thus avoids two extremes. Against Advaita, liberation is not absorption into an undifferentiated absolute. Against Buddhist anātman, it is not release without an enduring self-substance. Yet critics ask how an intrinsically perfect soul could be beginninglessly obscured and how material action and moral consequence (karma) affects consciousness. Jainism answers that the conscious soul (jīva)-action and moral consequence (karma) relation is anādi but terminable and that embodied conscious soul (jīva) has pradeśas through which action and moral consequence (karma) associates with it. These replies preserve internal coherence but leave an interaction puzzle.

Therefore the quotation is accurate. Jaina liberation (mokṣa) preserves substantial identity while transforming every karmically conditioned mode. Purification and transformation are not rivals: the former explains continuity, the latter the radical difference between saṃsārin and siddha.

Why this earns marks

- Interprets the quotation through the central substance (dravya)-mode (paryāya) distinction.
- Reconstructs the complete bondage-and-release mechanism.
- Integrates ratnatraya, vows, eight karmas and guṇasthānas.
- Distinguishes sayoga-kevalī, ayoga-kevalī and siddha.
- Uses Advaita and Buddhism for controlled comparison.
- Ends with a synthesis that preserves both continuity and transformation.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Can Jaina pluralistic realism consistently sustain both epistemic humility and the claim to omniscience? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Establish the realist and pluralist ontology.
- Derive epistemic humility from finite cognition and standpoint theory.
- Test the compatibility and evidential burden of perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna).
- Reach a graded verdict rather than dismissing either side.

Full answer

Jainism is pluralistic because it accepts infinitely many conscious soul (jīvas) and five irreducible kinds of non-conscious reality (ajīva); it is realistic because substance (dravyas), qualities (guṇas) and paryāyas exist independently of cognition. Reality itself is **ananta-dharmātmaka**, possessed of indefinitely many aspects. Many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) is therefore ontological complexity, not subjective construction.

Epistemic humility follows from the condition of the ordinary knower. Mati and śruta depend on senses, mind, signs and karmic limitation. Such cognition apprehends an aspect rather than the whole. Standpoint analysis (naya-vāda) legitimises partial standpoints while warning against their absolutisation; qualified assertion (syādvāda) makes assertions conditional; sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī) systematises affirmation, negation and inexpressibility. Humility is thus disciplined realism: one may know truly without knowing exhaustively.

At first, omniscience seems to threaten this architecture. If no assertion exhausts reality, how can a kevalin know all aspects? If Jainism invokes perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) to guarantee the truth of its system, the doctrine may become circular. A Cārvāka or modern empiricist will add that unlimited cognition lacks public verification.

The Jaina answer distinguishes finite discursivity from the intrinsic cognitive power of the purified soul. Mati and śruta are mediated; avadhi and manaḥparyāya show degrees of unmediated cognition; perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) is complete manifestation after knowledge-obscuring action and moral consequence (karma) is destroyed.

Non-absolutism is therefore not the claim that exhaustive knowledge is impossible in principle. It is the claim that finite, karmically conditioned standpoints must not masquerade as such knowledge.

This reply has three strengths. First, it prevents humility from collapsing into scepticism: standpoints track objective aspects. Second, it gives soteriology an epistemic goal: purification enlarges cognition. Third, it allows the doctrine to explain its own possibility-comprehensive teaching ultimately rests on kevalin knowledge.

However, these strengths create burdens. The graded series from sensory cognition to omniscience does not by itself prove that the final term exists. Reflexively qualifying many-sided reality (anekāntavāda) preserves consistency but

may weaken its universal authority. Further, if perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) is non-discursive, its communication through language again enters partial standpoint-forms. The omniscient content may be complete while every transmitted proposition remains conditioned.

The most coherent interpretation therefore separates ontological, cognitive and linguistic levels. Reality is objectively many-sided; ordinary cognition is partial; perfect knowledge (kevala-jñāna) is postulated as comprehensive; linguistic communication remains selective even when sourced in comprehensive cognition. On this reading, humility and omniscience are logically compatible but not evidentially equal.

Jainism can consistently sustain both claims because they concern different epistemic conditions. Yet consistency is not proof: omniscience remains the system's strongest internal culmination and its greatest external evidential vulnerability.

Why this earns marks

- Establishes pluralism and realism before turning to epistemology.
- Derives humility through mati/śruta, standpoint analysis (nayavāda), qualified assertion (syādvāda) and sevenfold predication (saptabhaṅgī).
- States the circularity and verification objections in strong form.
- Gives the graded-knowledge and karmic-obstruction reply.
- Adds the sophisticated distinction between complete cognition and selective communication.
- Delivers a graded verdict separating logical compatibility from evidential proof.